

CFA® Program: MS in Finance

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Which sheet? Wealth management or financial planning: CFP. Investment research or portfolio management: CFA. Investment banking or private equity: Investment Banking. Real estate lending, investment, or development: Real Estate. Students can combine them. All sheets: willgerken.com/roadmaps

What it is

The professional credential for **investment management**, the work of research analysts and portfolio managers at funds, pensions, and other institutions: three sequential exams (Level I tools and ethics, II asset valuation, III portfolio management), roughly 300 hours of study each, plus 4,000 hours of qualifying work experience. Pass rates are typically below half at each level. The MSF and the CFA cover much of the same ground, which is why Gatton's MSF is a **CFA Institute Affiliated University program**.

Timing

You already hold a bachelor's degree, so you are **eligible for Level I now**, with no waiting period and no graduation-month rule. Most students who sit during the degree take Level I in the first year and Level II after finishing. Registration windows and fees are on cfainstitute.org; ask about the affiliated-university scholarship before you register at full price.

How the MSF maps

The MSF is 30 credit hours: **ten courses chosen from a list of twenty-three**, with no required courses. Nothing forces CFA coverage, so the ten you pick decide how much of the exam material you see in class.

CFA topic	MSF course
Ethical and professional standards	<i>FIN 600</i> ✓ Corporate Financial Policy, which has carried the CFA Institute Online Ethics Course, seven modules, one per Standard. It is the only course that covers ethics, and it is optional, so take it.
Quantitative methods	<i>FIN 688</i> ✓ Financial Analytics Tools; <i>FIN 630</i> Financial Modeling and Analysis
Economics	<i>FIN 680</i> ✓ Money, Interest and Capital; <i>FIN 623</i> International Financial Management
Financial statement analysis	<i>ACC 621</i> ✓ Understanding Financial Statements
Corporate issuers	<i>FIN 600</i> ✓ Corporate Financial Policy; <i>FIN 645</i> Corporate Investment and Financing Policy
Equity investments	<i>FIN 650</i> ✓ Investments; <i>FIN 640</i> ✓ Valuation of Firms and Financial Assets
Fixed income	<i>FIN 675</i> ✓ Fixed Income Securities and Markets
Derivatives	<i>FIN 652</i> ✓ Options, Futures, and Derivatives; <i>FIN 670</i> Risk Management and Financial Strategy
Alternative investments	<i>FIN 668</i> ✓ Alternative Investments and Private Markets; <i>FIN 664</i> Real Estate Finance
Portfolio management	<i>FIN 685</i> ✓ Investments Practicum; <i>FIN 686</i> Investments Practicum II

A CFA-aligned ten

FIN 600 Corporate Financial Policy · **ACC 621** Understanding Financial Statements · **FIN 688** Financial Analytics Tools · **FIN 650** Investments · **FIN 640** Valuation of Firms and Financial Assets · **FIN 675** Fixed Income Securities and Markets · **FIN 652** Options, Futures, and Derivatives · **FIN 668** Alternative Investments and Private Markets · **FIN 680** Money, Interest and Capital · **FIN 685** Investments Practicum

That is all ten, and it touches every exam topic. Ethics rides on FIN 600, so if you drop that one, plan to work the CFA Institute ethics material on your own. Sensible swaps: *FIN 670* for FIN 652 if you want risk management rather than pricing, *FIN 686* to stay in the practicum a second term, *FIN 660* Trading, Markets, and Regulation for market structure, *FIN 630* Financial Modeling and Analysis if you arrive without modeling skills, *FIN 662* Insurance and Risk Management for an insurance or risk career.

What Gatton offers

- **CFA Institute University Affiliation** for the MS in Finance and the BBA in Finance. Affiliated programs receive student scholarships that cut the exam cost; apply through the principal contact.
- **Real-money portfolio management** (FIN 685, FIN 686): students manage part of Gatton's roughly \$5 million Student Managed Investment Fund, drawn from the University endowment, and present to the endowment committee.
- The CFA Institute Research Challenge, the Stock Pitch Competition, and Bloomberg certification.
- The MSF is a **STEM-designated degree**, so international students are eligible for three years of OPT.

Two 400G courses (ECO 491G Applied Econometrics, MA 427G Financial Mathematics) appear on the catalog's MSF list. Confirm with the program director that they count toward the MS before planning around them.

Admission. A bachelor's degree in any field with a 2.75 GPA or better. No GMAT or GRE. The degree needs a 3.0 GPA across the ten courses.

Principal contact: Will Gerken, CFA, will.gerken@uky.edu · Program director: Igor Cunha, igor.cunha@uky.edu · Course list and requirements from the 2026-27 UK Graduate Catalog (Finance, MSFI); topic mapping follows Gatton's filed CFA course map.

A general guide, not official advising. Compiled from publicly posted UK catalog and curriculum pages; requirements change and no warranty is given. Confirm your plan with your academic advisor and your myUK GPS degree audit.